



One last time?: Sunil Chhetri turns 42 next year, and with no clarity on the next ISL season, the Bengaluru FC forward might just call it a day with a final flourish in the Super Cup.

FSDL/ISL MEDIA

sponsorships and finances for several clubs — notably Odisha FC, which will not participate in the Super Cup for the first time.

The club won the tournament in 2023 and reached the final in 2024. Meanwhile, Churchill Brothers — the 2013–14 Federation Cup champion — withdrew from last season's Super Cup and have also opted out of this edition.

There are, however, reasons for excitement among fans. Three-time national champion Dempo Sports Club enters the Super Cup for the first time, replacing Real Kashmir and reviving a whiff of nostalgia for vintage Goan football.

The Golden Eagles have struggled to rise to prominence since their withdrawal from the I-League in 2016.

Having earned successive promotions back to the I-League in 2024, Dempo finished in the top half last season and will hope to continue their ascent in the Super Cup.

Hyderabad FC, the 2021–22 ISL champion, will play its first tournament reborn as Sporting Club Delhi under coach Tomasz Tchórz.

The tournament pits Bagan and East Bengal — one of the few embers still burning bright — against each other in the group stage, for a fourth Kolkata derby this season. East Bengal has won the first two, while Bagan claimed the latest to lift the IFA Shield on October 18. The Red-and-Gold Brigade ended a 12-year drought of national trophies with the Super Cup in 2024 and will look to add another under new coach Oscar Bruzon.

Defending champion FC Goa will look for an early Christmas on home soil, with coach Manolo Marquez rejoining the side after a nightmarish stint as India coach.

He has won three trophies in India — two of them, the Bandodkar Trophy and Super Cup, with the Gaurs — and will fancy a fourth, riding on local support.

The last dance?

The 2025–26 Super Cup could also be a potential swansong for India's record goalscorer, Sunil Chhetri.

The striker came out of international retirement in March but has not found the net in competitive fixtures since.

Chhetri turns 42 next year, and with no clarity on the next ISL season, the Bengaluru FC forward might just call it a day with a final flourish in the Super Cup.

For Chaubey, too, this might prove to be the last waltz, with elections looming in September next year.

Looking inward and rebuilding the domestic structure has always been the foundation for revival in footballing nations.

The Super Cup might just serve as a catalyst for the same, a reminder that even in turmoil, hope endures for those willing to search in the right direction.